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Ken Poston

Ken Poston is the Founder/Director of the L.A. Jazz Institute, and Director of Concert Productions at KKJZ Radio in Los Angeles. His devotion to and enthusiasm for the art form is inspiring.

Ken was interviewed via Zoom on June 4, 2024 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: I don't see my –- hold on — where is my — okay. We are going so I'll have to just edit this part out. All right.

KP: Yeah I got a window that just now popped up.

MR: Okay. Very good. Okay. My name is Monk Rowe and I'm very pleased to have Ken Poston with me this afternoon — morning for you I assume?

KP: Yeah I guess so, pretty much, late morning I guess.

MR: So I want to share a sort of an image I just got hooking up cords and so forth to do the Zoom and plugging things in I was thinking while I was doing that how to succinctly introduce you. So I have something to try on. It sounds like this: Ken Poston, jazz hub.

KP: Okay. There you go.

MR: With many inputs and outputs.

KP: There you go, I like that.

MR: It would be curious for me to be perhaps standing in the background if you were at some kind of party and a person who didn't know you asked what do you do. What would you say, in thirty seconds?

KP: I'd probably just say that concert production, radio, teaching, run a jazz archive, and the things that come off of that like writing and lecturing and things like that. So that would be the succinct version I guess.

MR: Did you have any idea when you were 18 or 19 that you would end up being a hub?

KP: No. No, at that point, just getting out of high school I chose a music scholarship to go to the University of Kansas, so I knew I wanted to do something related to music but I wasn't exactly sure even going into school what it would be. And of course the choices were music performance or music education. And I really didn't have any designs on being a professional trumpet player, so I went into the education program. But again, really, coming out of school it was almost a last minute decision to take the music scholarship. I also played baseball and if you would have told me anytime up until about three or four months before I was out of high school that I would have done anything other than follow baseball I would have laughed. I would have thought that was

ridiculous. But something happened where I decided that I really wanted to pursue the music side of things and so I went with the music scholarship at Kansas.

MR: I'm sorry, was Gerry Mulligan in your consciousness at that time?

KP: Maybe through Chet Baker. Because when I really started to get interested in jazz I would have probably been eighth or ninth grade, and I was trying to find records of trumpet players even though I didn't — maybe didn't know who they were — to play along with, or to try to play with. And so I had come across Chet Baker. And Chet was actually one that I could actually somewhat play along with. Miles, you know, a little bit, but then Dizzy Gillespie, you know no. You know I found a Dizzy Gillespie record and you know, I couldn't do that.

MR: How about Maynard Ferguson, right? Oh there's an easy one.

KP: Yeah, and I'm of the age to where Maynard was like the big star in the '70s you know and I mean so all the, you know everybody, all the trumpet players especially idolized Maynard Ferguson. And I, you know I loved it too but I knew that I couldn't do that and I didn't know if that was something that I would ever be able to do, but I recognized the fact that I could only go so far with the Maynard things before I'd have to go down an octave or two.

MR: Was there a point when you were trying to play along that you started to realize the relationship between the trumpet notes and the background? The chords or the bass line?

KP: When I got into coll — or into high school I started to get more and more curious about some of those things. And I remember going to the Walden Book Store in the mall and I bought Bill Russo's *How to Arrange for Jazz Orchestra*. And I actually wrote a chart. And my teacher helped me a little bit, and there was a student teacher there at the time that helped me a little bit, but I didn't know what I was doing at all, and Russo's book is not that easy to digest, especially when you don't know anything, but it showed me the ranges of the instruments and things like that, so I could piece something toget — so I actually wrote a chart that's — you know very simple, but I was able to then kind of match harmony up to what was going on and the counter lines and everything, I was actually able to start to figure some of that out. And I finished it and we were able to play it. I don't think we ever played it in public, again, it wasn't anything that was earth shattering but I taught myself some of that. And then when I got in college though and had to take the music theory classes, I kind of taught myself the wrong way. So it didn't exactly match up because I kind of had just done this by the piano and figuring out what fit together and sounded right. So when I actually got into music theory classes it was a little, I don't know it was probably no more difficult than it would have been but it was difficult at first for me.

MR: Can you recall the name of the chart? Was it a chart that something else you were arranging — another tune?

KP: I do. And the funny thing is one of my friends came up with it and it was "So What" but none of us ever heard the actual "So What" at that time. So I think my friend thought it would just be a funny title, like you know so what? And so that was the title of it, and had no idea that it was the title at that point, because apparently I hadn't run across "Kind of Blue" yet. So you know that was, like I said probably eleventh, twelfth grade I guess.

MR: Yeah. I have a very similar experience. I believe I did "Well I Think I'm Going Out of My Head." You know for the high school jazz band. And it probably didn't work very well but there's nothing like that first time you hear something back that you've toiled over, especially with paper and pencil.

KP: That was the only time I ever did it, but it was a great exercise in kind of at least starting to understand things that I didn't understand before. But hearing it played back was kind of fun. I remember I spent a long time writing a bass line. It was a blues. I mean it was a 12-bar blues. But I wrote out a bass line that I figured out on the piano. And I remember the bass player in the band was just like, "It's a blues, I don't want to play that." And the teacher is like, "No, play what he wrote." And he's like, "Well I don't want to play —" and things like that you know, but you don't know. And I remember I did not write a drum part because I couldn't figure that out. I had no idea how to even begin to do that.

MR: Yeah. And it's still difficult.

KP: I let that go. I didn't have any interest in that at all.

MR: Eight bars of time. That's what you want right there. I'm going to see if I can put this — I was going to save this for later but it seems to me in reading about jazz history and society that at different periods jazz has had a place in American society, if it was the jazz era and the music that went with it — of course the swing era, the avante garde period, civil rights, that jazz has had an impact on that part of society. You don't have to necessarily agree with me but I wonder if you think jazz — what is the role of jazz in society in 2024?

KP: Well yeah, that's a great question. I think — I mean the thing to me right now, I mean I think it's, what I've noticed over the last few years is this great desire to kind of blur the lines of jazz and other musics. I assume that's for commercial purposes. I never really thought too much about it, but at the radio station I see it all the time with CDs that we get and things like that. So I think jazz is at a point, for the 2024 part of it, I think there's a certain perception — it may not be the same by everyone in society but I think there's a certain perception of jazz and what jazz is and what it represents. And I think it's, you know we're in an age where it's celebrated at Kennedy Center and at the White House and at Lincoln Center and things like that, which you know prior to what the 1980s that

really didn't happen too much. So as jazz has become thought of as — and all the key words and all the phrases everyone uses of America's classical music and this and that, I think it's made people aware to a certain degree that it's an important American creation and important to our society and important to our culture. The sad thing is is I don't think it has educated people any more so as to what it is or why, but I think that there's a perception of it as being — and I think you could say that probably about decade by decade, that the perception has changed or altered or enhanced as we get to this point. But yeah, it's tough 'cause I know just from personal experience, at least for me, is that I think it's more difficult now as it's ever been to have successful events and to have successful projects related to the music that — to draw an audience. In other words, I think unless something is subsidized, having it subsidized by a paying public is as difficult now as it's ever been, unless it's a festival or an event that uses the term jazz very loosely but it's more of a music festival that has performers on it that will draw a big crowd. And of course as we know we've seen more and more of that, and that's what I said in the beginning, this blurring of the lines kind of, you know that jazz has touched so many kinds of music that it's okay now for rock groups to headline jazz concerts, or for whatever the case may be. So I don't know if that's healthy or unhealthy but it's just something that I have to deal with on a daily basis, because the tendency — I mean if you're not really passionate about it, and if you're not really, you know depending on what's your reason for why you're doing what you're doing, it's easy I think to take the easier road of festival headliner or concert headliner or something that will guarantee. Now people will argue that that's okay. You know people will argue that that's okay you know, if it takes a certain headliner to subsidize the event so that everybody sees and hears everything else then that's okay. I mean I certainly think you could make a case where it's okay but I think there's times it's not okay as well. So, and I think there's times that it's unnecessary. So I guess that's, you know that's kind of an issue today.

MR: Yeah. As a producer of events is part of your task to go out and find some of those people and companies to subsidize these concerts?

KP: It should be but I've never really done it. Pretty much everything I've ever done is based on the audience attendance. There's a few exceptions to that but not really anything where I had gone out and sought it out but I've had a couple of occasions where a sponsor has come to me. And frankly I've had some we've turned down that didn't — that what they wanted in return for sponsorship would have altered the event or the purpose of the event. So it's — so no, that's not something I've done. It's something that if I was smarter I would have done maybe, but never done it. I've always worked from a standpoint of trying to understand the audience or whatever segment of the audience that I'm going to promote something to, and find a way to get them excited about going. It's

not that hard to find the audience. I mean we know where they are, but you've got to convince them in this day and age to get in the car and go somewhere and that's harder today than it's ever been. That was the other thing I was going to say from your earlier question is with the advent of Zoom, the advent of streaming, the advent of all these things, everything is much harder for me anyway today. Radio for example — we're still a terrestrial radio station but people can stream and listen to anything they want to listen to at any given time, they can create their own radio stations, they can create their own playlists, they can — so to me we've had to alter our approach with terrestrial radio — at least we have — to make sure that we create something that gives people a reason to listen to us as opposed to just listening to whoever they want to hear at any given time. And it's kind of the same with the events because of new technologies. I think Covid played a role in teaching people how to use Zoom and streaming and teach people how to attend an event without actually going there. Things like that. I'm not saying that's a bad thing necessarily but it's different. So that to me is, all those things combined are what's different now and more challenging — at least more challenging for me.

MR: That phrase is going to stick in my head, how to attend an event without really going.

KP: Yeah.

MR: Yeah. And how do you take the pulse of the Southern California area to try to program the acts and the artists that will bring those people? Is it partly your radio work or word of mouth?

KP: It depends what it is and what we're doing because kind of the sequence of events for me was what used to be KLON Radio in Long Beach, which now is K-JAZZ, so I was there for 13 or 14 years producing concerts and festivals and on the air as well. Then the Los Angeles Jazz Institute, which I still operate the Jazz Institute, but then almost ten years ago now I became the general manager at KSDS in San Diego because I truly wanted to see jazz radio continue. And I decided I could continue to do all the other things I did as well as run the radio station so all of those things as far as — they have different approaches. Like for the radio station when we do events there's usually a concept or a reason why we're doing it. Because I've never felt as a radio station that our role is to compete with other area promoters who are struggling too — whether it's clubs or festivals or whatever. So I've always felt with the radio station aspect that what we do there has to be something very unique, very special, or has to have some unique aspect of it. That's why I've rarely — I say rarely but I guess in percentage-wise — I'm usually not in a position where I'm just hiring a set group to play for an occasion. I'm usually having to create something, and put something together whether it be a reunion of sorts or whether it be putting a band together to play someone's arrangements — whatever the case may be, that's always been more of the direction, especially with radio. Because

again, you know there's — our job with radio is to promote what the local promoters are doing, to try to help them, not to compete against them. So we do things — again — for a purpose. Sometimes the purpose is as a fundraiser for the radio station. Sometimes it's to showcase something or an artist or maybe to celebrate a historical occasion or to celebrate something — a new release, or whatever the case may be. Jazz Institute is a little bit different in that the archive is the centerpiece of the Jazz Institute. And this large archive that we've built over the years, that has many artist collections — most of which are Southern California related. I knew from working with all the artists, and when we started this, that the idea was that a lot of them complained about donating their materials to a place where they're going to be locked away and never heard from again. And I knew that ideally what Pete Rugolo and Shorty Rogers and Bud Shank and some guys like that, what they wanted really, even if they wouldn't come right out and say it, was that their legacy would continue after they were gone. So we decided with the Jazz Institute where the archive would be the centerpiece and then the events and the festivals and things that we did would all utilize materials in the archive to be able to showcase and maintain those legacies. And for the first several years when we were doing it, many of the musicians were still alive. Now that's not the case now — we're just about out of a lot of the musicians of the eras that these collections represent. But we've been able to utilize the music, by doing concerts of their music, we've been able to utilize the recordings by doing a series of CD reissues of rare materials, things like that. Now I can — obviously I marry the two together so I can incorporate some of those things now into the radio element as well, but then also all those events always were multi-day — or I should say are, not was — panel discussions, film showings, utilizing the films, presentations that utilize photographs and memorabilia and audio and so on. So that's been our focus with the Jazz Institute is to really utilize these materials and keep them a living, breathing thing, and not just lock them away. Because the amount of researchers, and you know you get a fair amount of serious researchers that are doing things and that's great, but still to me to keep those things alive. And then they become natural fundraisers for the institute that way because theoretically you're raising money from doing the events. So the radio purposes are related but a little bit different and then the institute archive purposes are a little bit different in approach, but they each have their own reasons as to why we do things.

MR: That's nice that you're able to marry those two aspects of your career together. I've had a similar thing I've been able to do with our archive and a local Arts-In-Education institute over the years, and it really works well if you think it out.

KP: Yeah. And that's really the key. And again, with your archive of making sure those things are available and having them there for people to access and things like that, that's so

important. But as you know, that's not always the case. And a lot of times — and I think the idea behind the whole thing started back in the KLON days when I started to put — not only was I doing the events but also the radio shows that I've always done have been more like kind of documentary oriented. And it seems like doing it on a weekly basis that that would be, you know that I've, you know, always put a lot of effort into it, a lot of research and I'm kind of built that way in that I always kind of have to have something that I'm working on. And I've always done that. So at night at home I'm reading, doing research, whatever the case may be, but I always kind of need that, whatever we're working on to really delve into and really go into it deeply. So the radio things become kind of natural from that in putting these documentary type programs together. I'll go interview the artists, find the music that was needed and so on and so forth. But what I discovered when I was doing these radio shows, and the events as well, is Shorty and all the different guys like Rugolo and all, they had all those things they'd done through the years, but they were in garages, attics, buried underneath things. And I realized there needed to be somewhere that gathered the stuff because what I would end up doing, like when we would do a concert that had something to do with Rugolo, I would be in his garage for two or three days finding all these original scores and then I would see all of Rugolo's original hand-written scores and acetates of unknown concerts and sessions. And I started to get really excited about all of that because it really augmented the things that we were doing and it enabled us to be able to do the events and present all these things and this was, 'cause at the time we're talking about ejazzlines did not exist. I mean there wasn't somewhere that if you wanted to do a concert of, you know, Ernie Wilkins' music, there was not a place you could go and rent those or buy those. I mean you had to get a hold of Ernie Wilkins and hope that he still had them. And that was the case for all of the things on the West Coast. I mean all those things. You had to find them. And so I did. You know I was able to uncover these things, and then it just naturally led to the idea that well there needs to be a repository on the West Coast for these musicians to leave their materials, and I just kind of decided that that would be something that I would like to do. So it crossed over with the last year or two when I was at KLON and then I dove into that full time for the next several years. And it was a good process because I was able to really work on finding all these things, gathering the materials, making arrangements with the musicians to archive the things, and digitize things, and really, really work on it like on a full time basis and then utilize the events — we would do two big events a year and then smaller ones in between, and those events would subsidize the whole thing. So up until we really started to lose a lot of the original musicians if you will — I say "original" meaning people that were doing the music of, or at least people related to who we're doing the music of. It started to change after that. It became more difficult

because people would get very excited over coming to see an alumni band playing. You know it all started with this big Stan Kenton event. I didn't even intend for that — I never intended for that to be the case. But when I first moved to Los Angeles to take the job at the radio station I got one of the union directories that published Local 47 union directories and I started going through it just to see who was around, and I couldn't believe that so many of — they still lived in the area, and the one thread that I noticed was that all the Kenton alumni going back to the first band we around. And it dawned on me that you could like really put together an alumni band of all these musicians and have Pete Rugolo, Lennie Niehaus, Shorty Rogers, Marty Paich, you know Hank Levy — all the writers — Bill Russo, Bill Holman — everybody was still alive. And you could actually have them conduct this alumni band. So we put together a four-day event for the radio station and it was huge. We had this huge attendance beyond what anybody expected. It made a great deal of money for the radio station at the time and it established that idea and it established an audience. So through the years as we continued to do these events, and this kind of goes back to your original question on this, we were able to continue to build a mailing list of people who came to these events. So over the years as this list grew and grew we had people that we knew wanted to attend these multi-day events and we had people that came to the local events and people — and we had a lot of people who would fly in even for the local events. Because, again, they knew they were going to see something that they couldn't see otherwise. I mean if you want to see this big Stan Kenton thing you pretty much had to come. It's not going to travel and it's not going to happen anywhere else. So we would put together things like that.

MR: And it's not going to be on YouTube just yet, right?

KP: Not yet, there was no such thing. So but see I loved every aspect of that, of — 'cause that's what I really love doing. And I did a big radio thing where I did a multi-week history of the Kenton orchestra, interviewed all the musicians that were going to be there. So we built up excitement, got people really excited about this thing that was to come and so on. Yeah back then we didn't even have a non-local audience. There was no — but I think there was that Kenton newsletter. I had no idea that there was this big almost cultish kind of following for Kenton. I'd never —

MR: I found the same thing and I just was finishing a podcast episode about band leaders and I included Mr. Kenton. And in reading it, the dichotomy between people who loved him and people who couldn't stand his music is really quite amazing. Even sometimes the musicians who played in the band.

KP: Oh absolutely.

MR: Yeah. Stan didn't swing you know.

KP: No. And there's not much in between you know it's either — and I remember my dad, I mean one of the things growing up I think that probably interested me in the music was my dad came from the swing era, and he had all the records and you know he loved the big bands. So I grew up hearing those bands. And when I started to play the trumpet in I don't know fifth grade, sixth grade, whenever you start doing that, I would — probably to please my dad, not that he insisted on that, but I thought it was fun to — he loved Harry James. I thought it was fun, I would figure out the notes — I didn't know anything about — I'm in like fifth grade or sixth grade — I didn't know anything about notation or anything but I would just write down the sequence of notes and I learned to play "You Made Me Love You" and things like that. And my dad would be thrilled you know because I could play his favorite Harry James tune. So I would hear these things. But I remember my dad did not like Stan Kenton. Didn't have any Stan Kenton records, didn't like that band at all. And the way I know that is because Stan Kenton, when I was in high school, came around — one of the clinics was at the Kansas City, Kansas Community College. And we got to go out to the clinic. And I was star-struck by all of that, just because, you know here's Stan Kenton and you kind of get to play with him 'cause he's playing the piano while you're playing. And it was a big deal. I remember thinking what a big deal. And my dad was like aagh, you know, never cared for that. So it's interesting because he's very representative of the side that just, you know, has no open mind about it whatsoever you know, it just didn't swing, didn't like it.

MR: I had the same experience, you know at SUNY Fredonia. He came there and I was star-struck and I kept thinking that's what I want to do. I want to be in a band like that. And as it turns out, you know, I'm more of a Basie guy. But still, there's nothing like that. I'm wondering if, in all your research that you've done about different people, especially on the West Coast, and you read what other people write about them, and then you get to know the actual person and you have conversations about them. Have you come across instances where what the actual person says refutes what has been written about them?

KP: Many times. Many times. Because as you know the West Coast scene of the '50s, by the end of the '50s there was a definite turning point within the critics and people writing about it where that music was very much dismissed and artists associated with that music got a lot of negative press as well. And so then I would — as doing the research, and you would read things, like you said, you would read these interviews and things about certain artists that just didn't — when I would meet them and get to know them it didn't add up at all. Even Gerry Mulligan. You know Gerry you know had this reputation, as you know, was temperamental and this and that and the other, and he was never like that with me at all. Now to be honest, I saw that side but not like people had described it. But Shorty Rogers, sweetest guy in the world, very easygoing. Marty Paich, very difficult

taskmaster. But you would read about the things people had written and a lot of times it just didn't match up with the person that I had gotten to know. And over the years I would get to know many of those guys on a pretty close level. Because the type of events, the type of things that I was doing kind of required working closely with them, working closely with them on the music, things like that. And then once you can kind of — the other things that I'm proud of is that I had stayed in — you know I was in music at KU long enough, probably about four semesters. I don't remember when I switched over to Radio/TV/Film, but in the music education side of things they sent us out as freshmen to student teach. And I got sent to a sixth grade string class, of course violins and violas. But you know I had the basic class and you know you have to — and I realized, this isn't what I want to do at all. I mean I respect it and I know it's necessary and I was a student, I mean but I didn't see myself doing that. So luckily they sent you out early enough that you could kind of see if that's what you wanted or not. So I had been listening for years to KANU, which was the jazz — at night at least — NPR station out of Lawrence, but at night it was jazz and on weekends, and the big, the well-known authority on jazz in the Midwest was Dick Wright. And Dick taught the jazz history classes at KU. And I took that first jazz history class and everything became clear for me. Because I'd read all the books I could find up to that point in the library at high school, but when I took that class I knew a lot of the names, but it all came together. I understood then when I took that class how everything fit together which I didn't know before. I mean I knew these different people but I didn't know exactly where they fit within the overall scheme of things, at least not on that level. So when I took that class it opened up everything and I decided at that point to switch to Radio/TV/Film. So I switched majors, started studying, and I went up to Dick one day after class and I said, "You know" I said — I was so shy and I'm still shy actually, I have to not be in certain circumstances but it took a lot for me to go up to him, and I said, "You know I really want to do what you do. I don't know how to do it but like you know I'd like to play jazz on the radio and I'd like to like teach jazz history because that's what I really like." And so I figured dozens of kids had probably gone up to him and said that, but of course no one else had ever said that, he'd been teaching for years. So he kind of took me under his wing and I got to work in the jazz research library there on campus. He had donated 10- 20,000 records at a time when none of those things were available. We're talking about early '80s then. I had access all of a sudden to everything I'd ever dreamed of being able to hear. Not only could I listen to it, I could make cassette copies of anything I wanted, and I had full access to everything. And it changed everything. And then I really delved into the idea of radio, and I really wanted to do the teaching. So for the next two years I immersed myself into that. I even went to summer school so that I could work in the library during the summer

because I mean I just couldn't wait to get in there and catalogue these things and listen to everything and it just — my education was, you know, quadrupled. But I was a Radio/TV/Film major so I got on the student station and became the jazz program director for a couple of years and was able to start to actually be on the radio and kind of learn how to do that, and of course Dick helped me and so on.

MR: You were a kid in multiple candy shops.

KP: It was, yeah. I mean I just — it was so lucky. But it was frustrating because I would just dive into the *DownBeats* and *Metronones* that they had in the library and I would see reviews of records that I could only dream of ever actually hearing. And I would see things written about it. And then all of a sudden when I'm able to work in this library, everything's there. And everything that I'd ever read about or wanted to hear, there it is. And so it was. It was an amazing thing. And I continued to play — I played all the way through school. Even though I switched majors I still continued to play in the jazz bands and the concert bands and all those things. But I never loved playing like you have to love playing. And I learned that when I — it had always come pretty easy to me and I was always really good, all through school. I was always able to be in all the state bands and the whole thing. And I didn't have to put that much effort into it. I never practiced like you were supposed to. My practice was playing along with records, and just kind of doing what I wanted to do you know. But I get to college and everybody's as good as I am and a whole bunch of people are way better. And I'm always, I mean I'm very competitive so that wasn't something that stopped me, but I noticed that like the people really serious lived in the practice rooms. I didn't want to practice like that. I don't want to practice at all. I didn't enjoy that. I enjoyed playing in front of people. I didn't enjoy that part of it. And at the point that I came to realize that I didn't have the love for playing that you might need, that's when I got more serious about this other avenue, 'cause I fell in love with the history and the things surrounding that, the listening to the thing and all. So when I fell in love with that it gave me a clearer path. And I started telling you this because of what you asked me, which now I don't remember, and I don't think I answered what you had asked me, but for whatever reason it made me think of all of that. It was somehow related to what you asked me.

MR: I think it was, indeed.

KP: I don't remember what it was.

MR: So I had the opportunity to interview Chico Hamilton and Buddy Collette and I was struck by — they spoke about the classic Chico Hamilton group and the fact that it had the cello and the guitar and it had this different sound. And what they both said made it seem like that whole thing happened out of just circumstantial like there wasn't enough

room for a piano, that — those kinds of things that are so logistical and look what they lead to.

KP: Yeah. I mean that was, you know, according to everybody it was an accident. And that's according to all of them: Chico, Buddy, Jim Hall, Fred Katz. I mean they all agreed that it all happened with Fred playing — you know Fred was a very accomplished cellist and I mean he looked like a cellist — I mean everything about Fred — and he was actually an anthropology professor.

MR: That makes all kinds of sense.

KP: You know flowing hair and you know — so Fred I mean he was a brilliant cello player and he would bring the cello to the Strollers Club in Long Beach and at the breaks he would play cello pieces. And then when the band got back on the bandstand Fred couldn't get back to the piano 'cause it was too crowded, and Chico said, "Just play the piano parts on the cello." I know that all sounds too good to be true but they all agreed that that's what happened. So you know — we know that's what happened.

MR: Well Chico said that the Gerry Mulligan Quartet was almost the same thing. It was no stroke of genius, it started in my living room and critics/historians everyone wants to make it something like a genius thing, and that's B.S. he said.

KP: Yeah I mean there's some of that. Chico and Gerry didn't get along too well after Chico left. And you would think that years later they would have let that go. Well Gerry didn't let things go very well. But Chico left the group to go with Lena Horne when the group had really hit you know. And Gerry just really kind of — you know Gerry would say that's all in the past, but then when you really talked to him off the record he never — because to him they had created this very special thing and Chico was a major part of that. And then when Chico left that group to go with Lena Horne, Gerry never really let it go too much. And that's what's funny too because I had many events where I would have the two of them with their own groups on the same event and they crossed paths but they really weren't too friendly so it was really true. But then you know I talked to Chico after Gerry died and Chico was very — I think it was more on Gerry's side probably than Chico's because Chico spoke at Gerry's memorial and you know he spoke very highly of him. But there was a little — there was that tension there. But Chico is correct in that it came together out of the necessity of the piano not being available when Gerry was offered. So I have no doubt. But the reality is Gerry had been thinking in those terms and this just made it make sense. A piano wasn't going to be available therefore if you could work without the piano you can have the job, and Gerry had been thinking along those terms so then they started to — and then it just turned out to be this once-in-a-lifetime miraculous thing that came together that wouldn't have come together probably with any other pieces of that puzzle you know. I mean it was the four people that came together

that, it just — I think it just made it work because you know Chet's role was a necessity, Bob Whitlock's role was a necessity, much more so than he gets credit for, and of course Chico's as well.

MR: Was there a financial incentive to keep the group together? Sometimes we make assumptions that these groups that find a niche and create a sound that they're being rewarded monetarily?

KP: I think that was — if it hadn't already happened it was certainly coming, and it had happened to a degree because the crowds at The Haig, where they were playing, even though The Haig wasn't very small — I mean there were literally people lined up around the block to get in. Dick Bock started the Pacific Jazz Record Company to record that group and immediately started to record them, and those records he couldn't keep up with the demand for the records, and then immediately went up to San Francisco and played The Blackhawk and then went back to The Haig and could have certainly then gone on the road but that's when Gerry ran into his problems and ended up in the Honor Farm for six months and that's when the group fell apart, that particular group. So the short time that it was together it had already become a major thing within the jazz world and if it had been able, I think, to go out on the road — there really weren't festivals yet per se in 1952-53, but there were package things happening, you know Jean Norman and Norman Granz.

MR: Norman Granz, yeah.

KP: So they would have certainly been in demand for those type things, but yeah it got cut short, not for musical reasons.

MR: Okay. All right here's a little scenario. I'm a guest speaker at a symposium, a jazz symposium, and you're in the audience and I come out and one of the things I say is, "A jazz band is the embodiment of an unfettered democracy."

KP: Well I agree. I agree with that. I've heard Wynton say that many times and I think it's — I mean you're talking it just being a democratic process.

MR: I am but I'm also quoting from a review on your Gerry Mulligan book and it said for one Mulligan took the managerial aspect of being a bandleader seriously. His approach pours cold water on the romantic ideal that a jazz band is about unfettered democracy.

KP: I could very much speak to that from personal experience in many of these things. It truly is a case by case, band by band kind of a thing. There has to be a leader. Gerry was always very specific and he's absolutely a thousand percent right, there has to be a leader. So it's a democratic process when they are actually playing together, because then that role isn't required. I mean you know then it's a process where they're creating music together and everyone has a role that they can take liberties with as needed and so on and so forth, unless it's a chart that you're playing necessarily, but even within that there's

interpretations. But even for what I do, and I learned very early on of having to put different bands together and create different things. You can't just usually put a band together and hope that — and say, "Okay we want you to play — we want you to do a tribute to Jazz at the Philharmonic and we want you to do a Jazz at the Philharmonic type concert" because there'll be a lot of standing around and either one of two things will happen. Either one person that's a Gerry Mulligan type will just step forward and start to take the reins and say okay well I think we should start with "I Got Rhythm," or there'll be a lot of standing around and not knowing what to do depending on who the participants are. So I had to learn through the years, sometimes the hard way, that sometimes that had to be me and that was hard for me to do because I had such — I was so much younger than the other people and I had so much respect for those guys that I never saw myself as someone who should be telling those guys what to do. But then you learn as you go that in certain cases you're ultimately responsible for it and you've got to make sure that what you want to have happen happens. So you either appoint a leader that's somebody who will do it, or you have to at least assume some of that role yourself. I would always obviously try to appoint a leader, but sometimes you would have to step in and do that. So yes, Gerry was not a guy — Gerry was very much a leader. And I think that's one of his attributes is the fact that Gerry had a vision and Gerry knew what he wanted and he knew how to get it and he had no problem being the leader. And that's the thing you know Gerry would say, and it's in the book you know it can't be a democracy. Well what he's talking about is that type of scenario. Now when Gerry would walk out unannounced at the Newport Jazz Festival to just participate in one of the jam sessions that he loved to do that might have been him and Coleman Hawkins and Ben Webster and whoever, then it's more of what we're talking about as a democratic process of those guys are playing together and there nobody is saying you only take two choruses, you know I mean there's more of a given — you know there's more of that process. So I think there's two sides to it and it depends on the circumstances and what you're doing. But I noticed that even from having to, you know a lot of things I've done there has to be rehearsals obviously, if you're doing big band concerts where you're reading, there has to be rehearsals to some degree. And I would always use, if I could, 'cause it was more appealing to me personally but it was also more of a selling point to the audience, like for example if you're doing a Stan Kenton alumni event playing Pete Rugolo's music and Pete Rugolo's the guy conducting the band, that's a big deal. But now Pete was not very comfortable in that role. Pete was very shy. Pete didn't like — Pete wasn't loud, he wasn't demanding. Pete would conduct but he just kind of expected everybody would do their job and he wouldn't have to discipline anybody or this, that or the other. Shorty was somewhat like that in that Shorty was not allowed — but usually those guys had so much

respect from the musicians that they would really, really buckle down when they were doing the rehearsals to show the respect. Sometimes not. Sometimes you would run into problems. But a guy like Gerry, that was never a problem. A guy like Marty Paich was never a problem, because they're going to get up there, and Gerry didn't care who it was. When we did those "Rebirth of the Cool" things we did a rehearsal before one of the concerts, that would have been in L.A. at A&M. Herb Alpert would let us use A&M sometimes when we needed to do rehearsals for something and we didn't want a bunch of people just kind of showing up and keeping us from getting things done. And you know it had Lee Konitz and Art Farmer and Brookmeyer. Was Brookmeyer in that? I think Brookmeyer was part — it was either Brookmeyer or Rob McConnell. And you know this was an all-star tentet. It didn't matter that it was Lee Konitz. It might have been somebody we've never heard of. It didn't matter that it was Art Farmer. Gerry was, you know, if Lee did something Gerry wanted different he would tell him. If Art Farmer did something Gerry wanted done differently he would tell him. So he was a great leader from that standpoint and at certain occasions it makes my job a thousand times easier. But I know, again, that statement is very accurate from that standpoint but also again I think we're talking about the democratic approach meaning ;that there's a certain amount of freedom within a jazz ensemble that you don't get otherwise, and those freedoms and how — because again with Gerry and Chet, and Gerry and the rhythm section from the original quartet, decisions, musical decisions as they were playing was made by them listening to each other and playing off of each other. I mean those things weren't, even the beginnings — even the endings of things that sounded preconceived weren't. These were guys who were very much aligned musically that were listening and playing off of each other, and of course in a small group setting, that's the most enjoyable thing, when the musicians are truly having a musical conversation among themselves, and when the piano player plays a certain harmony to something the trumpet player, the saxophone hears it and goes that direction and so on and so forth. That's the type of thing when I'm listening to things that I love to hear is when you really hear that interaction, so —

MR: Do you have a place that you wish you could have been, to get in a time machine and experience a particular recording, a particular event?

KP: Yeah, I mean I guess we all have that. I don't know if I could pinpoint one in particular but obviously Charlie Parker either you know the "Koko" session maybe or you know maybe a specific event but something. You know that was a name that I grew up with in Kansas City that helped me get into things because there was somebody that I knew was important, just like Count Basie, even when I didn't know where they fit within things I knew they were important. So Charlie Parker, not for that reason but just for musical reasons I would love to be in that company of one of the historic events. I think as far as

the West Coast things are concerned I would have loved to have been able to hear that group with Gerry and Chet at The Haig for example. I'm sure I could think of dozens more but you know off the top of my head those type things, you know, hearing Dizzy and Bird together in their prime I think would have been for me — now of course I'd love to have heard Bix Beiderbecke, I would love to have heard Louis Armstrong and the Hot 5 session. I would love to have been able to actually witness some of those landmark big bang type of an event but you know all we can do is we listen to them thousands of times throughout our lifetime and we get as close as we can that way I suppose.

MR: Yes. And on occasion we get to be in front of our musical heroes, which I did once with Cannonball Adderley, who is still my guy.

Addendum, separate insert follows:

KP: Count Basie was coming to Kansas City and because we had played all those Sammy Nestico charts in the high school band, I knew who — Count Basie, I'd read about Count Basie and the connection to Kansas City that I thought for the school newspaper I was going to write a big history of Kansas City jazz and this would be great if I could interview Count Basie then that could be a part of my Kansas City jazz history and it'd be really great in high school to be able to do that. So our principal knew somebody and was able to get it set up for me to interview Count Basie backstage at the Uptown Theater. That would have been 1978 or 1979, somewhere in there. And of course I was scared to death and I made my questions up, I had five or six questions, and I knew I only had about ten minutes with him or whatever it was. So I get there and they've got all the journalists who, everybody but me was like a real journalist. And I'm sitting there, got my suit on and I got my little tape recorder and the microphone and I'm terrified that the mic is not going to work or whatever the case may be. But there's I don't know six or seven other journalists there that are all set up to interview. So they're not there yet, but I'll never forget, the stage door swings open and the Basie band starts coming in. And I'm sitting right there. And all of a sudden Freddie Green walks in. And I knew, I'd done my homework enough, I knew who all these guys were, and here's Freddie Green. And all of a sudden this reality comes over me about oh my God that's Freddie Green, I have to interview — thinking I can't do this, and so I'm starting to get really scared once I saw Freddie Green. And then Basie comes in. And Basie comes in, everybody's clapping, he's got the captain's hat and the cigar going, and they put him in this room and I'm thinking to myself okay, well I can pull myself together, look at my questions, there's all these other journalists so give me some time to get together. Of course I'm the first one called. Immediately they called me. So I go in and I asked my first question which was so — these were all very pedestrian questions. You know, "What was the Kansas City jazz scene like when you were —" something like that. First thing out of Basie's mouth,

which I heard him do many other times but I didn't know this at the time but I heard him do this in many other interviews, "Oh well you see I'm writing a book. I'm writing my biography, and I can't talk about those things that are going to be in the book, so you got any more questions? And of course you can imagine like a 16-, 17-year-old kid that has — and I don't know what to do. So I kind of re-phrased the question. I guess I don't know what I said but I kind of re-phrased it. And then Basie goes, "You know that's kind of the same question." And I go oh well — "What about Lester Young?" Lester Young. "Yeah, Lester Young was a stylist." That's all he said. I'm, oh, so I'm running out of my questions and I'm not sure what to do. So finally I just start winging it, 'cause I see this isn't going to work and it scared me when he wouldn't answer the question. So I just said, "Well," I said, "thanks" I said, "I just wanted to tell you you know my high — I'm in my high school band and we don't play anything — we play all the Sammy Nestico charts. The minute I said that his whole demeanor changed, and he just became — he was so thrilled you know. "Oh you play my music?" I'm like, "Yeah we play 'Wind Machine' and this and this and this. He's like, "Oh" he goes, "man" he goes, "I would sure like to hear you guys." I said, "Well" you know, "you should come over to my school." He goes, "I will, next time I'm in town you get a hold of me and I'll come over and hear you guys." And it never happened but I was able to take the tape back and play it for everybody and everybody's like, "Oh my God." So then after that he started answering my questions. So I ended up getting some stuff from him because all of a sudden, and that taught me kind of an interesting thing too is that the way that the musicians view you makes all the difference in the world. If you gain credibility with them, which often you have to do I think — I think what's helped me through the years is having the music background has helped me and in some ways separated me from some other people who do what I do, certainly not everybody. But I'm able to speak that language, and also then in doing the interviews I speak a language where I can ask certain questions that — and I realized, and I don't know if I realized it right at that moment or not, but gaining the respect of the musicians and gaining credibility opens many avenues for you with the musicians that you might not get if they just kind of write you off as, you know, somebody who doesn't know or hasn't done their homework or really didn't. So but that's the Basie story. Real quickly you could — I'll real quickly tell you a fast Jay McShann funny thing from when I was in Kansas City. Jay and I went to lunch about once a week when I was working at the Kansas City Jazz Commission. There were places Jay liked to go, I think there was food he wasn't supposed to be eating but I never — I'd pick him up and we'd go wherever he wanted to go: Gates & Sons, and Arthur Bryant's, or wherever it may be. There was Ruby's Soul Food not too far from where my office was, and we went to Ruby's Soul Food. And we're sitting having lunch and this woman,

a younger woman, comes over to Jay and she says, "I know you. My mom has all your records. I know you, you're famous." And Jay, you know, you know Jay, Jay was real humble and you know Jay's like, "Oh well." "Yeah, yeah, I know who you are. My mom has all your records. I grew up listening to you." And Jay's like, "Oh." She goes, "You're Bobby Blue Bland." And so Jay starts trying to convince her that he's not. And I'm just sitting there cracking up you know. And Jay's like, "No, no, my name's Jay." And she's like, "No, I know who you are, you're Bobby Bland." He goes, "No, my name's Hootie. I'm Hootie." She goes, "No, I know who you are. You're Bobby Blue Bland. My mom has all your records." And this goes on for — I'm just cracking up. Jay keeps telling her he's Jay McShann and she keeps insisting he's Bobby Bland. So then she whips — she goes, "I've got to get your autograph for my mom." And she whipped something out of her purse, sticks it in front of Jay. So I'm watching Jay to see what he's going to do. Sure enough, he signs it Bobby Blue Bland and gives it back to her.

MR: Oh that's great. Thank you for that.

MR: What is the — is there any racial issues these days in booking concerts and diversity that you take into account with the productions that you manage?

KP: Yes. I make sure, and I always have, even years ago before it was maybe as necessary even as it is today, but I'm always very conscious of those things and I try to take into account how what we're doing is going to be perceived and so if we're doing some kind of a historical event that doesn't — maybe that doesn't have the diversity for natural reasons or for reasons that, for whatever reasons that it can't, I'm always aware enough of it to be able to discuss it or explain it or put it in the right perspective. But in this day and age, especially at the radio station, we're on a college campus of course and as you know that's a very, very important item right now — diversity is something that everyone is concerned about on every level at the college. And so everyone who works there and everyone who is in certain positions, even with us at the radio station, are expected, I'm sure, I mean no one comes out really and says it that way but I know we're expected to approach what we do with all things considered. Now that doesn't mean that you can always be all inclusive but it means that when you can you should be and you should make attempts maybe, and what we do is we make attempts to design certain things that open the door to specifically have that be a point of what we're doing is to do things that represent a diversity whether it's a racial diversity or other.

MR: Yeah, I know what you mean. I do a —

KP: We've been real careful with that.

MR: Yeah.

KP: And I don't mean careful from the standpoint of you know trying to get by with that, it's not that at all, it's that we just try to make sure that we're doing things — taking everything into consideration and doing things the right way.

MR: Right.

KP: And I've always kind of wanted to do that. I've always tried to do things — what I — in my mind at least is the right way. You know it was — I mean obviously, and again I keep going back to the Kenton thing but that's just 'cause that was kind of the one that established these things. If you're going to do a Stan Kenton reunion you're going to be very short on African-American musicians, you're going to be very short on female musicians. Now there are some, and we include them, as far as female musicians I mean you know Mary Fettig's been at a number of the events but you know Mary Fettig off the top of my head is about the only one I can think of that was a female musician that actually played in the Stan Kenton Orchestra. There are black musicians who were in the Kenton orchestra through the years, but not very many, and that's where you get a lot of the racial things being written about someone like a Stan Kenton and so on and so forth with that. But again we try to, when we've done the Kenton things we've tried to address that, not to hide from it but to try to address it so that it's presented in a way. Not presented necessarily — because I don't pretend to be able to read anybody's mind as to why this happened or didn't happen, but here's how it happened. Here's historically what happened. And you know, so —

MR: It does make sense. We have a kind of event here every year that I organize and sometimes it's much like a jazz party where I call one person and I say, "Bring a band. Bring whoever you would like." What I don't say or have a hard time saying is: it would be a plus if it was a diverse quintet and I find that hard to say.

KP: It's hard 'cause you can't — you know it's hard to tell the musicians, you know, to change whatever the make-up of the group is or whatever. But it's yeah — and I understand it and it's something important and I understand that it's important but again it's just one of those things that I don't think there's any right way or wrong way to approach it. I think it's just a case by case basis for us as to whatever we're doing, whatever we're focused on and how we can best address things the right way and be inclusive, you know, when we can. And we do that a lot now. And again, I don't ever like doing things for the wrong reasons. I mean I don't like being inclusive 'cause you feel like you have to, I like to do it because there's a valid reason to do it. And so we try to, we try to still maintain a certain level of accomplishing what we set out to accomplish and do it the best way that we can. You know again it's night and day, the difference between the jazz institute and how we can put things together there and have a lot of freedom, versus when we put together things for the radio station there's another layer or

many layers that you deal with when you're at the college. You know there's many different layers. Whereas at the Jazz Institute there's none of those layers you know. You can pretty much do things exactly — people get paid exactly how you need to get — you know all those things. At the college it's a whole different thing as you well know. So again you have to adapt, you have to adapt to the circumstances, which is what we've always tried to do but I can say that I feel pretty good that we've not made compromises and I'm proud of that without events. I don't feel like we've ever made compromises to try to make more money or to try to bring in more people or whatever the case may be. We've always just tried — my thing has been is that there's enough of an audience out there, especially where I am in L.A. and San Diego — there's enough of an audience out there that will support what you're doing, you just have to — you just have to find out — to get them to listen to the radio or to attend the event, or whatever it is that you're trying to get them to do. I don't have visions of — I don't have visions that there's — like for example in San Diego I'm sure that a huge percentage of people who like jazz or even on a very periphery like jazz, they know our radio station exists. We don't necessarily have to go find some unknown thousands of potential audience out there that doesn't know we exist. We have to get the people who are our audience to support the radio station during fundraisers and things like that. And just like any public radio station, classical music or jazz, either one, the percentage of people who donate during membership drives is a teeny-tiny percentage of the listeners. I mean it's like I don't know four percent or something. It's a tiny percentage. If we could get half of the people who listen on a regular basis just to become a member we wouldn't have a care in the world for years. But it's never been that way and I don't have any visions that we're going to necessarily be able to change that, but you just keep trying to get that percentage to go up. And it's the same with events. You know I don't go buy billboards on Sunset Boulevard when we're doing a jazz festi — a straight ahead jazz festival because I'm spending money to reach an audience that's not going to come no matter what. So I always try to focus more on getting the message to the audience that's there, not to try to — and again if our, maybe our purpose is to do something where we're trying to enlarge the audience and then we might do different things. But see for the Long Beach Blues Festival that I did for years and years, now that was a little bit of a different animal, because the Long Beach Blues Festival did attract and could attract and appeal to a more commercial audience or a different audience depending on who you had as headliners and people attending. So yeah, we'd buy bus placards sometimes or whatever you call those things on the side of a bus. And we would take out full page ads in the *L.A. Times*. I would never take out a full page ad in the *L.A. Times* for, you know, a West Coast jazz festival that featured Shorty Rogers and Gerry Mulligan and Howard Rumsey and so on and so

forth. But for the blues festival, yeah, because we would have, you know, B.B. King and you know people like that. And they appeal — so you approach it a different way. Blues festival we'd get 20,000 people a day. Again, I never had any visions that our West Coast Jazz Festival would get 20,000 people. I knew that if we could draw a couple thousand people collectively over the four days or three days or whatever it is, that it would all work out just great. So I don't want to paint the wrong picture. It's not that I don't realize the importance of developing the audience and expanding the audience, we certainly do try to do those things. But there's a lot of people doing that that I'm sure is doing a good job with it so you know we try to give them something good that as they expand that audience they have somewhere to send them.

MR: Right.

KP: We do our part with that, certainly with the radio station I mean you know expanding the audiences.

MR: Speaking of that, last question: You're programming music, it's your own show and you get a CD in of someone who's hot and you don't like it. Do you play it?

KP: I don't. No. You're talking about for the radio?

MR: Yes.

KP: Yeah. The way we handle it, and this is on me because I'm the one who has said this is how we're going to handle it, our music director gets — I can't even begin to tell you how many CDs we still get a day.

MR: Even CDS they get?

KP: Yes. A huge amount. They haven't fully gone to sending files because the digital files still tend to get lost in the mix. But you know there's a whole — I started to use the word "industry" that's probably not the right word but there's a whole industry of radio promotion people that represent artists and labels, that their job is to call the music directors and get them to make sure their artists are played and report the number of spins that that's getting each week so that it shows up in the jazz Top 40 as, you know, those type things. And there's a lot of pressure from those kind of things because they're very good at it, you know they call you certain days that you set it up for them to call and they can convince you that — "Really need your help with this one" to do this or that. I've told our music director and I've told our hosts as well, don't ever play anything that you don't like or that you don't think is good, I don't care what it is. We do a pretty good job now of, our music director doesn't put anything into the library, or doesn't put tracks in that we don't feel should be there. So then we're on a system where everything is digitized. So they have access to the CDs but most of our on-air hosts, they're pulling stuff up and picking it out from — and what our music director is giving them are approved-of, you know there shouldn't be anything in there that we're going to ever be

listening to the radio and think how'd that get played. It happens from time to time obviously. But I've told our people, and I believe strongly in it, don't let outside sources dictate what we play, that — send us the things, if it fits our format and if we think that it fits and if we want to play it we'll play it, and if not no amount of calling and asking for favors and things is going to work. You know that works to a degree but yeah I mean I don't believe — now are there exceptions to that? To me no. But I think you treat local artists, you have a little bit more leeway with local artists maybe, just because you know again, you want to support the local jazz scene. Now having said that I mean I can't think of any local artists that we don't want to play the things they do, but theoretically you know you would maybe have a little more leeway. But no I think it's important to maintain your integrity. I've always been, with everything I've always kind of gone with the idea of maintaining your integrity. I also think though that you should be learned enough, if that's the right word — I think you should also do all your preparation. I think you should know enough that you could make those kind of decisions because on the same hand too you look — this is all hypothetically — but around the country you may have music directors that just happen to get the job as the jazz music director that doesn't have the knowledge or the experience or anything like that. Then what do you do? Because again, the idea of, you know, someone being in a position at a radio station to judge whether this is — it's like a jazz critic I suppose as well. I mean I expect our people to know enough to be able to make a decision. Their decision may not agree with mine, but the person in that music director job I think needs to be knowledgeable enough to make the decisions that the things that go into the library fit our format.

MR: All right.

KP: And we have one of those. And I think that — but I don't know that everybody does. But then again I don't know that they don't. I don't want to sound like I'm saying other stations don't do the same thing, but it's just, to me it's important that you do that. That's always been the question, as you well know, with jazz critics, you know who is this person to critique the album? Do they have musical knowledge or do they have knowledge of whatever enough to be able to — because in the old days you know a bad review could destroy something.

MR: Yes. So I appreciate your time today and I feel like you might be playing hooky from one of your multiple jobs.

KP: I'm on my way as soon as we're done.

MR: All right.

KP: I've got a few things we have to do today.

MR: Well thanks for your time and it's been fascinating talking to you, and I hope we cross paths sometime in the future.

KP: Oh that would be great, I would love it. And thank you so much, I really enjoyed it, and enjoyed the good questions.

MR: All right. I'm going to pause us and we'll say our good-byes.

KP: Okay.